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20

B2 readings with glossary



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20 articles at B2 · Upper-Intermediate.
Each opens on a photograph, comes with a glossary, and ends with speaking and essay questions.



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ARTICLE 01 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

GREEN PACKAGING

Companies are currently in a race to develop eco-friendly packaging. While packaging plays a crucial role in modern marketing, much of it poses a threat to our planet.

01

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Companies are currently in a race to develop **eco-friendly packaging**. While packaging plays a crucial role in modern marketing, much of it **poses a threat** to our planet. This is mainly because producing packaging consumes vast amounts of energy, and once it becomes waste, materials like cartons and wrappers are often difficult to **dispose of properly**.

In many countries, people are increasingly aware of the damage that modern lifestyles are inflicting on the environment. Many are now **actively seeking** ways to protect the environment for future generations. As a result, politicians and scientists are seriously **looking into** energy conservation and waste management, aiming to make them more environmentally sustainable.

> *"Plastic goods and packaging create waste that is particularly challenging to eliminate.*

In the realm of packaging, it's essential that materials are either recyclable or biodegradable. For instance, rather than simply throwing newspapers and glass bottles into regular household waste, people in several countries are encouraged to use designated containers for recycling. Certain household waste, like vegetable peelings, is naturally biodegradable, meaning it **decomposes naturally** over time.

However, **man-made materials** are not so easily dealt with. Plastic goods and packaging create waste that is particularly challenging to eliminate. This leads to the need for enormous landfill sites where plastic waste is buried underground, potentially **causing problems** for future generations. This also means the waste is not being **repurposed**.

Industrial waste **presents a similar challenge**, as factory effluent often contains chemicals that can pollute water sources. Factory waste must be carefully monitored to prevent such pollution. It's important to **implement safety measures** to prevent this.

Technological advancements, including nuclear power, have further **exacerbated** the waste problem. The disposal of nuclear waste is particularly concerning due to its radioactivity, which **potentially endangers** life. This waste is a **severe hazard**.

The high standard of living enjoyed in many countries has led to a significant increase in waste production. This could have a **devastating impact** on the planet's ecology. There's no doubt that **decisive action** must be taken urgently to protect our environment from potential disaster. It's crucial to **promote sustainable practices** to ensure a healthier future for all.

Glossary

01 **eco-friendly packaging**
Packaging that is designed to be environmentally responsible and sustainable

02 **poses a threat**
Represents a danger or risk

03 **dispose of properly**
To get rid of something in the correct and safe way, especially waste

04 **actively seeking**
Making a strong and deliberate effort to find or obtain something

05 **looking into**
Investigating or examining something

06 **decomposes naturally**
Breaks down into simpler substances by natural processes

07 **man-made materials**
Materials that are created by humans, not found in nature

08 **causing problems**
Creating difficulties or issues

09 **repurposed**
Used for a different purpose than originally intended

10 **presents a similar challenge**
Poses a comparable difficulty or problem

11 **implement safety measures**
To put safety precautions or actions into effect

12 **exacerbated**
Made worse or more severe

13 **potentially endangers**
Has the possibility of putting someone or something at risk

14 **severe hazard**
A very serious danger or risk

15 **devastating impact**
Extremely destructive or damaging effect

16 **decisive action**
Firm and determined action that is likely to be effective

17 **promote sustainable practices**
To encourage and support methods that can be maintained over time without harming the environment

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 What do you usually do with packaging after you buy something?

2 Should shops be required to use only recyclable packaging? Why or why not?

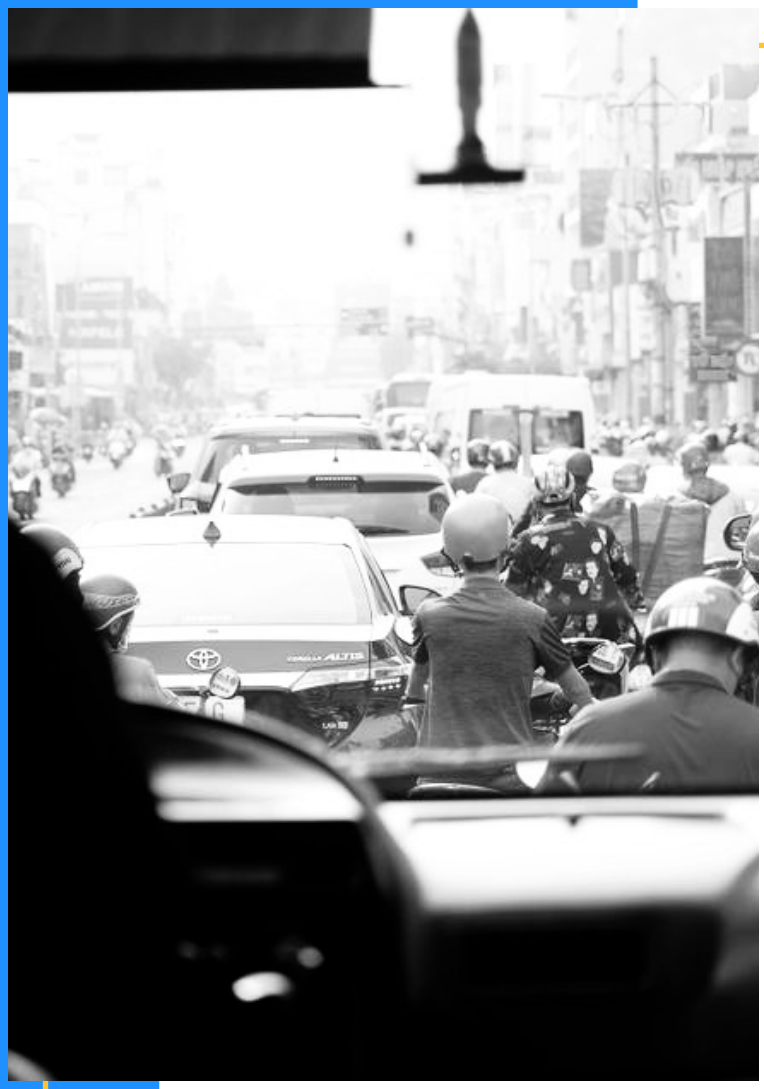
3 Who should be most responsible for reducing waste: governments, companies or individuals?



TRY TO USE eco-friendly packaging | poses a threat | dispose of properly | actively seeking | looking into

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people believe that companies, not consumers, should pay the cost of recycling the packaging they produce. To what extent do you agree or disagree?



ARTICLE 02 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

TOO MUCH TRAFFIC

Many of the challenges facing governments today are global in nature. A prime example is traffic congestion.

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Many of the challenges facing governments today are global in nature. A prime example is traffic congestion. Major cities worldwide are struggling to **devise solutions** for the ever-increasing number of vehicles and the resulting road congestion. This issue demands attention and innovative strategies.

A significant contributor to urban traffic is the prevalence of private cars. Despite persistent traffic jams, many drivers are **hesitant to abandon** their vehicles and opt for public transportation. They often view buses, trams, and trains as alternatives for others, preferring the convenience of door-to-door driving. Consequently, our roads are frequently **gridlocked** with traffic.

> *Otherwise law-abiding citizens sometimes take liberties when it comes to traffic regulations.*

Naturally, finding parking can be a challenge. While some companies provide parking facilities for their employees, most people must rely on public car parks, often multi-story structures, or attempt to park on the street. Given the often **stringent restrictions** and abundance of parking meters, finding a space becomes a source of frustration for many drivers. This situation often leads to stress and wasted time.

Otherwise law-abiding citizens sometimes **take liberties** when it comes to traffic regulations. They may disregard 'NO PARKING' signs or painted lines indicating parking restrictions. Even if they exceed the time limit on a parking meter, they might not worry – until they find a parking ticket on their windshield and realize they face a fine. This behavior highlights the temptation to bend the rules when convenience is at stake.

To address this, authorities in numerous cities are attempting to **discourage car use** in city centers. They have pedestrianized large areas and implemented park-and-ride schemes, encouraging people to leave their cars on the city outskirts and complete their journey by bus. These measures aim to reduce traffic volume in the most congested areas.

Despite these efforts, there are concerns that escalating traffic levels will cause complete **standstills** in cities, especially during rush hour. With frequent tailbacks and **bottlenecks** on numerous roads, driving is no longer an enjoyable experience. This raises the question: why do so many of us **persist in using** our cars, even when faced with these inconveniences? Perhaps it's time to **re-evaluate our reliance on** personal vehicles and explore alternative modes of transportation.

Glossary

01 **devise solutions**
To create or think of a plan or method for solving a problem

02 **hesitant to abandon**
Reluctant to give up or leave something behind

03 **gridlocked**
A situation where traffic is so heavy that no movement is possible

04 **stringent restrictions**
Strict and severe limitations or rules

05 **take liberties**
To act with freedom that exceeds what is allowed or appropriate

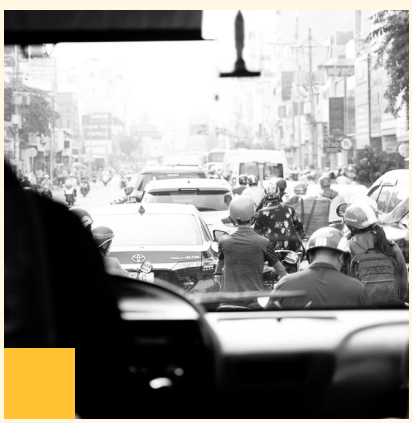
06 **discourage car use**
To try to persuade people not to use cars

07 **standstills**
A situation in which all movement or activity has stopped

08 **bottlenecks**
A place where a road or passage is narrow or blocked, causing traffic to slow down or stop

09 **persist in using**
To continue to use something despite difficulties or problems

10 **re-evaluate our reliance on**
To think again about how much we depend on something



SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 How do you usually travel around your town or city, and why?

2 Why do so many people prefer driving to using public transport?

3 What would persuade you to leave the car at home?



TRY TO USE devise solutions · hesitant to abandon · gridlocked · stringent restrictions · take liberties

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people think the best way to reduce traffic in cities is to make driving more expensive, for example through higher parking fees. Others believe better public transport is more effective. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

BULLYING



ARTICLE 03 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

Education plays a crucial role in a child's development, yet a growing number of students are reluctant to attend school.

03

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Education plays a crucial role in a child's development, yet a growing number of students are **reluctant** to attend school. This isn't always due to academic difficulties or fear of teachers. Instead, many children are experiencing bullying, which can have a devastating impact on their well-being.

Bullying in schools can take many forms, making victims' lives incredibly difficult. Bullies often **exploit** their physical advantage to intimidate smaller or weaker students. They might threaten violence if their demands aren't met, often resorting to physical force to **extort** money or steal possessions. This creates a climate of fear and insecurity for the targeted individuals.

> *Some psychologists suggest that a bully's desire to dominate others stems from their own feelings of insecurity or personal unhappiness.*

Verbal abuse is also a common tactic employed by bullies. Victims are often targeted for being different in some way. This could be anything from having red hair or wearing glasses to not owning the latest clothes or having a different family structure. These perceived differences can make them a **prime target** for bullies, who may engage in hurtful name-calling and other forms of verbal harassment. These attacks can be **deeply damaging** to a child's self-esteem and confidence.

Some psychologists suggest that a bully's desire to dominate others stems from their own feelings of **insecurity** or personal unhappiness. While this might offer some insight into the bully's motivations, it doesn't lessen the pain and suffering experienced by the victims. The problem is so **prevalent** that many schools have been forced to develop formal policies to address it. These policies often include clear guidelines for reporting and addressing bullying incidents.

Teachers encourage students to report bullying, but many victims are afraid to come forward, fearing further **retaliation** or increased harassment. Bullies may accuse them of being "tattletales" and make their lives even more miserable. Furthermore, bullies can often be **deceptive**, appearing charming and well-behaved to adults while **tormenting** their peers. This makes it difficult to gather evidence and hold them accountable for their actions.

Because reporting bullying can be challenging, and proving it is often difficult, many bullies **evade** punishment. It is essential that we protect children from this form of **persecution**. They have the right to feel safe and secure at school and to enjoy their education without fear. Schools must work to create a **supportive environment** where bullying is not tolerated, and victims feel empowered to speak out and seek help. **Raising awareness** and promoting empathy are key steps in preventing bullying and fostering a more inclusive and respectful school community.

Glossary

01 **reluctant**
Unwilling and hesitant; disinclined.

02 **exploit**
To make full use of and derive benefit from (a resource).

03 **extort**
To obtain (something) by force, threats, or other unfair means.

04 **insecurity**
The state of being open to danger or threat; lack of protection.

05 **prime target**
Someone or something that is very likely to be attacked or criticized.

06 **deeply damaging**
Causing serious harm or injury to someone or something.

07 **prevalent**
Widespread in a particular area or at a particular time; common.

08 **retaliation**
Action taken in return for an injury or wrong; revenge.

09 **deceptive**
Giving an appearance or impression different from the true one; misleading.

10 **tormenting**
Inflicting severe physical or mental suffering on.

11 **evade**
To escape or avoid, especially by cleverness or trickery.

12 **persecution**
Hostile or ill-treatment, especially because of race or political or religious beliefs.

13 **supportive environment**
An atmosphere that provides encouragement and assistance.

14 **raising awareness**
The act of increasing public knowledge and understanding of an issue.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 What makes a school a safe and friendly place for students?

2 Why do you think some young people bully others?

3 What should a student do if they see someone being bullied?



TRY TO USE reluctant · exploit · extort · insecurity · prime target

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people say schools are responsible for preventing bullying, while others believe parents play the bigger role. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

04



ARTICLE 04 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

GROWING OLD

Growing old is an inevitable part of life, something we all face despite our best efforts to postpone it.

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Growing old is an inevitable part of life, something we all face despite our best efforts to **postpone** it. While cosmetic procedures like surgery and hair dye can temporarily mask the signs of ageing, they can't stop the clock. Medical advancements have certainly helped people live longer, but the focus should be on maintaining a good **quality of life** as we age. The ageing process affects everyone differently; some remain healthy and independent well into old age, while others require support earlier.

One of the most challenging aspects of ageing is the potential decline in mental sharpness. It's common for older individuals to experience short-term memory loss, even while easily recalling distant memories. In some cases, this can **progress to** dementia, often in the form of Alzheimer's disease, a condition that gradually worsens over time. However, it's important to remember that this isn't the case for all older people.

> *"This type of discrimination, known as ageism, often leads to older individuals being unfairly labelled as frail and unproductive.*

Many senior citizens maintain their mental **faculties** and view retirement as a chance to enjoy newfound freedom. Those with good pensions may even find themselves financially comfortable, able to **indulge in** holidays and other luxuries. As a result, businesses and governments are increasingly aware of the economic and social influence of older people, often referred to as the "**grey market**".

Unfortunately, respect for older people isn't universal. While some cultures are known for their **veneration** of elders, in many societies, older people are **relegated to** a low status and treated accordingly. This type of discrimination, known as **ageism**, often leads to older individuals being unfairly labelled as **frail** and unproductive. Those who hold such views should remember that ageing is a universal experience and that they too will one day be in the same position. It is important to **foster** a society where older people are valued and respected for their wisdom and experience, not **dismissed** because of their age. We should strive to create inclusive environments where everyone can **age with dignity**. This includes ensuring access to appropriate healthcare, social support, and opportunities for continued learning and engagement. By **challenging stereotypes** and promoting intergenerational understanding, we can build a more equitable and supportive society for all.

Glossary

01 **postpone**
To delay something until a later time.

02 **quality of life**
The standard of health, comfort, and happiness experienced by an individual or group.

03 **progress to**
To move forward to a later or more advanced stage.

04 **faculties**
Inherent mental or physical powers.

05 **indulge in**
To allow oneself to enjoy the pleasure of.

06 **grey market**
The market consisting of older people, especially those who are retired or semi-retired.

07 **veneration**
Great respect; reverence.

08 **relegated to**
To assign to a lower rank or position.

09 **ageism**
Prejudice or discrimination on the basis of a person's age.

10 **frail**
Weak and delicate.

11 **foster**
To encourage the development of something.

12 **dismissed**
To treat as unworthy of serious consideration.

13 **age with dignity**
To grow old in a way that maintains respect and self-worth.

14 **challenging stereotypes**
Actively questioning and disputing widely held beliefs about certain groups of people.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 What role do older people play in your family?

2 What can young people learn from older generations?

3 Is it better for elderly people to live with their families or in care homes? Why?



TRY TO USE postpone | quality of life | progress to | faculties | indulge in

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

In many countries people are living longer than ever before. What problems does this create for society, and what can be done to solve them?

ARTICLE 05 · B2

PARENTAL ASPIRATIONS





In today's world, educational qualifications are widely considered paramount. They are almost essential for securing well-paid jobs in professional fields.

05

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In today's world, educational qualifications are widely considered **paramount**. They are almost essential for securing well-paid jobs in professional fields. Consequently, most parents try to encourage their children to study diligently and achieve academic success by performing well in exams. Many parents also **aspire** for their children to attend university and graduate with a respectable degree.

However, not all children have the **aptitude** for academic success. This is perfectly acceptable, provided parents can accept it. Unfortunately, it's common for parents to believe that hard work alone guarantees exam success. Too often, they simply create excessive stress for their children, potentially leading to illness or exam failure that could have been avoided. This can **undermine** their children's confidence and well-being.

> *"Each generation tends to have different perspectives, making communication between them incredibly challenging.*

Some children may be intelligent but simply lack interest in traditional schooling. They might possess an artistic **inclination**, wishing to become artists or designers, or they might have a talent for acting. Others may demonstrate a **knack** for practical work or a desire to start their own businesses and become entrepreneurs. It's entirely possible for children to **fulfil** these ambitions. However, their parents may have different ideas, which can cause family conflict. Interestingly, many parents are **hesitant** to let their children follow in their own footsteps. For instance, actors might discourage their children from pursuing a career in theatre due to the **precarious** nature of the profession. Business owners might believe their children would gain more prestige in an academic field than in the business world.

The opposite situation also occurs. Parents who have worked hard to establish a business might want their children to join it, only to find that their children prefer entirely different careers. This can lead to **disappointment** and **misunderstanding**. Each generation tends to have different perspectives, making communication between them incredibly challenging. This is the **genesis** of what is commonly known as the generation gap, a **phenomenon** that can strain family relationships. Bridging this gap requires **empathy** and a willingness to understand each other's viewpoints, allowing children to **pursue** their own paths while maintaining strong family bonds and **mutual respect**.

Glossary

01 **paramount**
More important than anything else; supreme.

02 **aspire**
To have a strong desire to achieve something.

03 **aptitude**
A natural ability to do something.

04 **undermine**
To gradually weaken or destroy something.

05 **inclination**
A feeling that makes a person want to do something; a tendency.

06 **knack**
A natural skill or talent.

07 **fulfil**
To achieve something desired, promised, or predicted.

08 **hesitant**
Unsure or slow in acting or speaking.

09 **precarious**
Not securely held or in danger of falling or collapsing.

10 **disappointment**
The feeling of sadness or dissatisfaction caused by the non-fulfillment of one's hopes or expectations.

11 **misunderstanding**
A failure to understand something correctly.

12 **genesis**
The origin or mode of formation of something.

13 **phenomenon**
A fact or situation that is observed to exist or happen, especially one whose cause or explanation is in question.

14 **empathy**
The ability to understand and share the feelings of another.

15 **pursue**
To follow or chase (someone or something).

16 **mutual respect**
Respect that two or more people feel for each other.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 Did your parents influence your choice of studies or career? How?

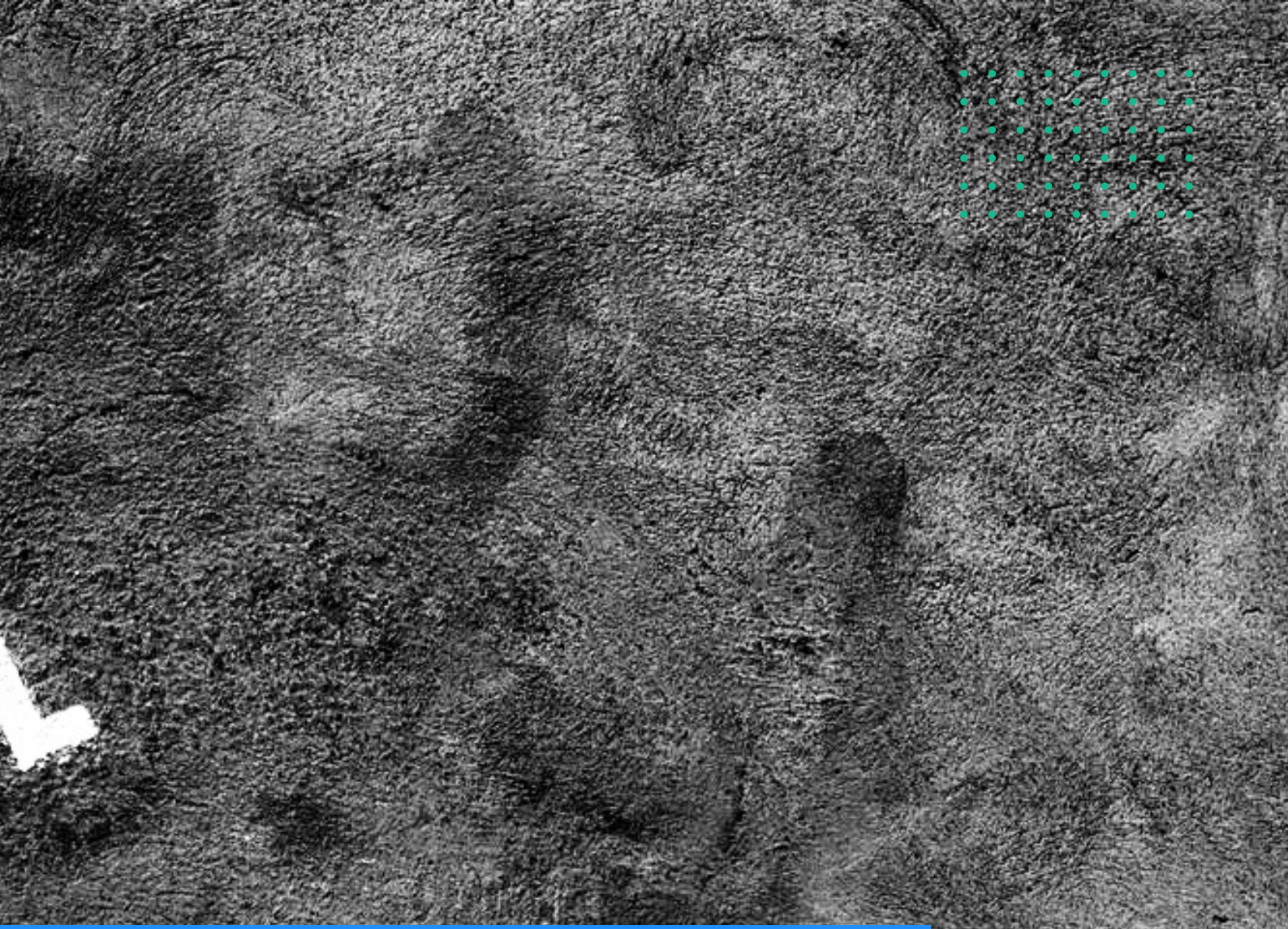
2 Is university the best path for every young person? Why or why not?

3 How can parents support their children without putting too much pressure on them?

TRY TO USE paramount aspire aptitude undermine inclination

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some parents believe their children must go to university to have a successful life. Others think practical skills and vocational training are just as valuable. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.



ARTICLE 06 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

DISCRIMINATION AGAINST DISABILITY

It's easy to fall into the trap of discriminating against people with disabilities, sometimes without even realising it.

06

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It's easy to **fall into the trap of** discriminating against people with disabilities, sometimes without even realising it. Often, able-bodied individuals **unintentionally patronise** those with disabilities, treating them like children. For instance, instead of asking a wheelchair user directly what they'd like to drink, someone might ask their companion, **effectively ignoring** the person in the wheelchair. Even when disabled people are clearly independent and travelling alone, they can be made to feel invisible, as if they **don't warrant** basic consideration. People may simply push past them without a second glance.

> *Many disabled people are perfectly capable of living independently at home.*

Naturally, disabled people have the same desires and interests as everyone else. They want to visit cultural attractions like museums and art galleries, eat out at restaurants, and generally participate in public life. However, **gaining access** to these places can present significant challenges. Public buildings often have steps at the entrance, which **pose a considerable obstacle** for wheelchair users. While some buildings now offer ramps, making access easier, this isn't always the case.

Narrow doorways can also be difficult to **manoeuvre through** for wheelchair users. Even after entering a building, further difficulties may arise. In older buildings, the only way to reach different floors might be a flight of stairs. Even if a lift is available, it might be too small to accommodate a wheelchair. Modern buildings are generally better equipped, usually featuring reasonably spacious lifts and escalators, which **significantly improve accessibility** for disabled people.

Many disabled people are perfectly capable of living independently at home. They might have a lift installed to access different floors, and a range of specially adapted appliances to help them manage everyday tasks. However, the moment they venture outside, they encounter a **multitude of barriers** that hinder their ability to live a normal life. Society must make every effort to **remove these barriers**. While some progress has been made in providing facilities for people with disabilities, much more needs to be done. Failure to do so risks **perpetuating ableism** and further marginalising this group.

Glossary

01 **fall into the trap of**
To unintentionally do something negative or make a mistake.

02 **unintentionally patronise**
To treat someone in a way that appears friendly, but which shows that you think you are better or more intelligent than them; without meaning to.

03 **effectively ignoring**
Having the same result as if you were ignoring someone, even if that wasn't your intention.

04 **don't warrant**
Not deserving or needing something.

05 **gaining access**
The act of being able to enter or use something.

06 **pose a considerable obstacle**
To create a significant problem or difficulty.

07 **manoeuvre through**
To carefully guide or direct something or someone in order to move or position them in a certain way, especially in a difficult situation.

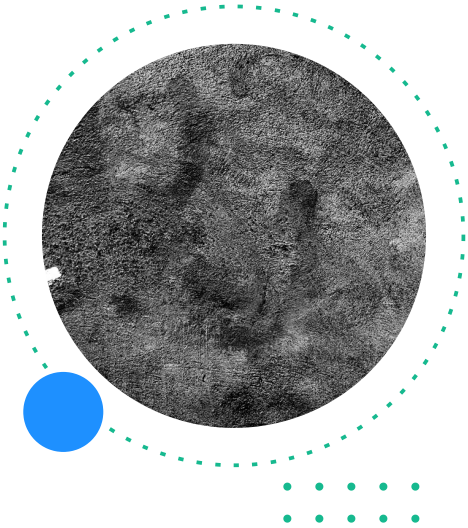
08 **significantly improve accessibility**
To make something much easier to access or use.

09 **multitude of barriers**
A very large number of things that prevent something from happening or someone from progressing.

10 **remove these barriers**
To get rid of the things that are stopping someone from doing something or progressing.

11 **perpetuating ableism**
Continuing to support discrimination and prejudice against people with disabilities.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 How easy is it for a wheelchair user to get around your town or city?

2 Why do people sometimes treat disabled people differently, even without meaning to?

3 What changes would make public places more inclusive?

TRY TO USE fall into the trap of | unintentionally patronise | effectively ignoring | don't warrant | gaining access

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people believe the government should spend much more on making public transport and buildings accessible to people with disabilities. To what extent do you agree or disagree?



ARTICLE 07 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

FOOTBALL HOOLIGANS

As football fever grips the world once again, the qualifying rounds for major tournaments like the World Cup are in full swing.

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As football fever grips the world once again, the qualifying rounds for major tournaments like the World Cup are in full swing. The sport's global **appeal** is undeniable, and these matches generate considerable excitement. At the club level, weekly games draw huge crowds, with fans **flocking** to stadiums, both home and away, hoping for a victory. The ideal match, in their eyes, is an **attacking** one, filled with goals and excitement. A dull, defensive game with endless, pointless passing is the last thing they want to see.

Unfortunately, the action isn't always confined to the pitch. All too often, **unruly** behaviour spills over into the stands. Football supporters, easily identifiable by their team's colours displayed on scarves and shirts, are known for their passionate, and sometimes **boisterous**, behaviour. They enthusiastically cheer on their team, singing loud, often partisan songs.

> *When trouble erupts within a football crowd, it can be extremely difficult to control.*

While rivalry between supporters is a natural part of the game, and mostly **harmless**, it can quickly escalate into something more serious. Fans can become enraged by perceived injustices, such as a referee's decision to issue an unfair card or **overlook** a foul committed by the opposing team. Such incidents can **ignite** tensions and lead to conflict.

When trouble **erupts** within a football crowd, it can be extremely difficult to control. Stadium authorities frequently segregate opposing fans in different sections of the ground as a preventative measure. However, managing potential conflict outside the stadium is even more challenging. In extreme cases, the police, sometimes in riot gear, are called in to **restore order**.

Sadly, a minority of fans actively seek out violence. These football hooligans see the game as an excuse for causing trouble, relishing clashes with the police and **inciting** others to throw objects. They view football not as a sport, but as an opportunity for **mayhem**. Their behaviour inevitably **tarnishes** the image of the game and **undermines** the enjoyment of genuine fans. Law enforcement agencies are constantly working to **clamp down on** such behaviour and ensure the safety of everyone attending football matches, striving to maintain the sport's positive reputation and **safeguard** the experience for all.

Glossary

01 **appeal**
the quality of being attractive or interesting

02 **flocking**
to go to a place or area, usually in large numbers

03 **attacking**
used to describe a style of play in sports that is intended to score goals or points

04 **unruly**
difficult to control or discipline

05 **boisterous**
noisy, energetic, and cheerful

06 **harmless**
not able or likely to cause harm

07 **overlook**
to fail to notice something

08 **ignite**
to cause a dangerous, excited, or angry situation to begin

09 **erupts**
to start suddenly and violently

10 **restore order**
to bring back a situation in which people obey the law

11 **inciting**
to encourage someone to do something violent, illegal, or unpleasant

12 **mayhem**
violent or damaging disorder; chaos

13 **tarnishes**
to spoil or damage something's reputation

14 **undermines**
to make someone or something weaker or less effective

15 **clamp down on**
to take strong action to stop something

16 **safeguard**
to protect someone or something from harm or damage

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 Do you prefer watching sport live or on television? Why?

2 Why do some fans become violent at matches?

3 Should football clubs be punished for the behaviour of their fans?

TRY TO USE appeal flocking attacking unruly boisterous

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people think fans who behave violently at sporting events should be banned from all matches for life. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

TRAVEL TROUBLES



ARTICLE 08 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

More and more people seem to be jetting off abroad for their holidays each year. However, this also means that an increasing number of travellers are facing the inevitable stresses and disappointments that can come with...

08

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More and more people seem to be **jetting off** abroad for their holidays each year. However, this also means that an increasing number of travellers are facing the **inevitable** stresses and disappointments that can come with international travel. The problems often begin at the airport, regardless of which airline you're flying with.

Especially during peak season, you're **virtually guaranteed** to encounter long queues at check-in, followed by further delays at passport control before you can even reach the departure lounge. Then, there's the often **agonising** experience of flight delays. While these are more likely with charter flights, scheduled flights are by no means **immune**. These delays can be caused by technical problems or the sheer volume of aircraft taking off and landing. However, in Europe, at least, some are due to **industrial action** by airport staff. Unfortunately, the holiday season is often a popular time for baggage handlers, air traffic controllers, or other airport employees to **take industrial action**.

> *With the sheer amount of luggage carried on planes, it's unfortunately quite common for bags to go missing.*

Despite these potential **setbacks**, you eventually make it to the departure gate, board the plane, find your seat, and buckle up, ready for take-off. The cabin crew will probably serve you food and drinks, and unless you're on a long-haul flight, the journey will seem relatively short before you land.

Upon arrival, you need to follow the signs to the baggage reclaim area and wait by the carousel for your luggage, hoping it hasn't been **mislaid** or sent to the wrong destination. With the sheer amount of luggage carried on planes, it's unfortunately quite common for bags to go missing. Luckily, this is usually a temporary situation. Luggage is tagged, making it relatively easy for airlines to track it down. Still, it's always a relief to be **reunited with** your belongings! It's an even greater relief to arrive home safe and sound, leaving us to **ponder** whether the trip was worth the effort. However, next year will almost certainly find us back at the airport, ready for another adventure, **come what may**.

Glossary

01 **jetting off**
Going on a trip by airplane

02 **inevitable**
Certain to happen; unavoidable

03 **virtually guaranteed**
Almost certain to happen

04 **agonising**
Causing great physical or mental pain

05 **immune**
Not affected by something

06 **industrial action**
Measures taken by workers to protest against employers

07 **take industrial action**
To participate in a strike or other form of protest against an employer

08 **setbacks**
A problem that delays or prevents progress, or makes things worse than they were

09 **mislaid**
To lose something temporarily by forgetting where you have put it

10 **reunited with**
Brought back together with someone or something

11 **ponder**
To think carefully about something, especially for a noticeable amount of time

12 **come what may**
Whatever happens



SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 Tell me about a journey that did not go as planned.

2 Is travelling abroad becoming easier or more stressful? Why?

3 What are the advantages of holidaying in your own country instead of abroad?

TRY TO USE jetting off · inevitable · virtually guaranteed · agonising · immune

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

More people than ever now travel abroad for their holidays. Do the benefits of international tourism outweigh the problems it causes?

09



ARTICLE 09 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

NEW RESEARCH ON COMPUTER GAMES

A recent study by a Japanese professor has unearthed evidence suggesting that computer games might negatively impact children.

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A recent study by a Japanese professor has **unearthed evidence** suggesting that computer games might negatively impact children. While many parents and grandparents have voiced similar concerns for years, they've often been **dismissed as** technologically resistant. These worries often **revolve around** the potential effects on children's physical health and social development.

Parents often feel that children should be outdoors, exercising and socialising with friends. Instead, many children play alone, leading to **social isolation** and limited opportunities for interaction, which can **hinder their communication skills**. There's also the concern that the violent content in many games could **desensitise children** to violence and potentially lead to more aggressive behaviour, a fear also associated with exposure to violent content on television.

> *"Using advanced technology, his research aims to demonstrate that computer games may impair brain development in children.*

Moreover, some worry that the **pervasiveness** of computer games contributes to a **general decline in** the complexity and depth of information that young people engage with. Because children may choose gaming over reading or homework, these games are thought to **impede their academic progress**. Parents are also concerned that excessive screen time might **stifle creativity**, preventing children from engaging in activities like drawing or writing.

Professor Ryuta Kawashima from Tohoku University shares these concerns about the **potential adverse effects** of computer games, but his research offers a more scientific perspective. Using advanced technology, his research **aims to demonstrate** that computer games may **impair brain development** in children.

His brain scans indicate that gaming primarily stimulates areas of the brain related to vision and movement. Crucially, the frontal lobes, which are **instrumental in** learning, memory, emotional regulation, and self-control, show **signs of underdevelopment**. If children's ability to control their behaviour is indeed being compromised, they might be more **prone to** aggressive outbursts. Professor Kawashima's research seems to **substantiate** parental fears about the potential downsides of computer games.

Glossary

01 **unearthed evidence**
Discovered proof or information that was previously hidden or unknown

02 **dismissed as**
Rejected or regarded as not worthy of consideration

03 **revolve around**
To be mainly concerned with or centered on something

04 **social isolation**
A state of complete or near-complete lack of contact between a person and society.

05 **hinder their communication skills**
To make it difficult for someone to develop or improve their ability to communicate effectively

06 **desensitise children**
To make someone less likely to feel shocked or upset by something, especially violence

07 **pervasiveness**
The quality of spreading widely throughout an area or group of people.

08 **general decline in**
A decrease or deterioration in something overall.

09 **impede their academic progress**
To delay or prevent someone's advancement in education.

10 **stifle creativity**
To suppress or prevent the development of creativity.

11 **potential adverse effects**
Possible negative or harmful consequences.

12 **aims to demonstrate**
Intends to show or prove something clearly.

13 **impair brain development**
To damage or weaken the growth and maturation of the brain.

14 **instrumental in**
Important in causing something to happen.

15 **signs of underdevelopment**
Indications that something is not growing or developing properly.

16 **prone to**
Likely to experience or suffer from something.

17 **substantiate**
To provide evidence to support or prove the truth of.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 How much time do you spend playing games or using screens each day?

2 Can computer games be good for children? In what ways?

3 Should parents limit how long their children play computer games?

TRY TO USE unearthed evidence | dismissed as | revolve around | social isolation | hinder their communication skills

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people think computer games harm children's development, while others believe games can help children learn. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.



ARTICLE 10 · B2

TERRORISM



The world was horrified by the terrible acts of terrorism in the United States. These actions have been rightly condemned by leaders worldwide, who see such terrorist activities as a serious threat to...

10

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The world was **horrified** by the terrible acts of terrorism in the United States. These actions have been rightly condemned by leaders worldwide, who see such terrorist activities as a **serious threat** to democracy and a **grave crime** against the American people.

> *The United States invests heavily in defence and intelligence.*

Terrorist acts are often **deliberately designed** to gain maximum publicity for the cause the terrorists support. The terrorists who crashed planes into the World Trade Center in New York certainly achieved **widespread attention**. The second plane attack was even broadcast live on television news channels around the globe, capturing the moment of impact.

The desire to **publicise their aims** usually leads terrorist groups to claim responsibility for acts of violence. However, immediately after the attack on America, no group **stepped forward** to take responsibility. Also, terrorist attacks on civilian targets often include some kind of warning. This **was not the case** in New York, and thousands of innocent people lost their lives.

The United States invests heavily in defence and intelligence. Yet, the country was completely **taken by surprise** by this attack. Many Americans had believed their powerful nation was **invulnerable** and were deeply shocked that terrorists could **breach their security** in such a way.

There are many different terrorist groups around the world, each **driven by** different motivations. These might include a feeling of political injustice, religious **zeal**, or simply hatred for those they attack. They are often a **hidden enemy**, using **secrecy** to commit brutal acts, and then disappearing without a trace.

The most difficult terrorists to deal with are those who are prepared to die for their cause. Their **fanatical hatred** of their targets means they are willing to commit suicide to inflict casualties on the enemy. World leaders now understand the global nature of many modern issues. The need to **eliminate terrorism** is, without doubt, one of the most important.

Glossary

01 **horrified**
Extremely shocked and disgusted

02 **serious threat**
A grave danger or risk

03 **grave crime**
A very serious offense

04 **deliberately designed**
Intentionally planned and created

05 **widespread attention**
Attracting a lot of notice from many people

06 **publicise their aims**
To make their goals widely known

07 **stepped forward**
Volunteered or came forward to take action or responsibility

08 **was not the case**
It wasn't like that

09 **taken by surprise**
Caught unexpectedly

10 **invulnerable**
Impossible to harm or damage

11 **breach their security**
To break through or violate their safety measures

12 **driven by**
Motivated or caused by

13 **zeal**
Great energy or enthusiasm in pursuit of a cause or objective

14 **hidden enemy**
An opponent whose identity is concealed

15 **secrecy**
The state of being kept secret

16 **fanatical hatred**
Extreme and irrational dislike

17 **eliminate terrorism**
To completely remove or get rid of terrorism

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 Where do you usually get your news, and how far do you trust it?

2 How has the way we hear about world events changed in recent years?

3 Why is international cooperation important for keeping people safe?



TRY TO USE horrified | serious threat | grave crime | deliberately designed | widespread attention

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people believe the media should limit its coverage of violent attacks so that attackers do not gain publicity. Others think the public has a right to full information. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.



ARTICLE 11 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

HEALTHY EATING

Most people want to live long, healthy lives. Doctors are increasingly emphasizing the importance of a healthy diet in achieving this, but we often disregard their advice.

11

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Most people want to live long, healthy lives. Doctors are increasingly emphasizing the importance of a healthy diet in achieving this, but we often **disregard** their advice.

While food **scarcity** is a major concern in developing countries, a different form of malnutrition exists in many developed nations. It might seem strange, but despite having plenty of food available, people can still suffer from a lack of essential nutrients.

> *Even when eating out, many people prioritize speed, opting for restaurants that offer immediate service.*

The problem is that many of us consume too much food that has little nutritional value, leading to a **deficiency** in vital vitamins and minerals. Our busy lifestyles often lead us to rely on **convenience foods**. Instead of taking the time to prepare a balanced meal, we often opt for quick options from the supermarket or freezer, ready in minutes in the microwave.

Even when eating out, many people prioritize speed, opting for restaurants that offer immediate service. This demand has led to the **proliferation** of fast-food restaurants in many countries. Unfortunately, much of this fast food is also **junk food**, and many children have developed a **preference** for these unhealthy options, refusing healthier alternatives.

Generally, we consume too much **processed food** and not enough **whole foods**. Ideally, we should eat more whole grains to increase our **fibre intake**, as evidence suggests this may reduce the risk of certain cancers. **Antioxidants**, believed to help prevent cancer, are found in significant amounts in fruits and vegetables. **Prioritizing** these is key for a balanced diet.

In the past, eggs and dairy were considered essential for good health. However, we now know that these foods are high in cholesterol, which can **contribute** to heart disease. This highlights the **evolving** nature of dietary advice.

While specific dietary recommendations may change over time, the fundamental message remains consistent: **be mindful** of what you eat! **Sustainable** and healthy eating habits are key to long-term well-being. It's about finding a **balance** that works for you and sticking to it.

Glossary

01 **disregard**
To ignore or pay little attention to something

02 **scarcity**
A situation in which something is not easy to find or get

03 **deficiency**
A lack or shortage of something

04 **convenience foods**
Food that is quick and easy to prepare, often pre-packaged

05 **balance**
An even distribution of weight enabling someone or something to remain upright and steady

06 **proliferation**
A rapid increase in number or amount

07 **junk food**
Food that is unhealthy but is quick and easy to eat

08 **preference**
A greater liking for one alternative over another

09 **processed food**
Food that has been altered from its natural state for safety or convenience

10 **whole foods**
Foods that are unprocessed and natural, like fruits, vegetables, and whole grains

11 **fibre intake**
The amount of dietary fiber consumed

12 **antioxidants**
Substances that protect cells from damage

13 **Prioritizing**
Treating something as more important than other things

14 **contribute**
To be one of the causes of an event or a situation

15 **evolving**
Gradually developing

16 **be mindful**
To be aware of something, especially something that might be important

17 **Sustainable**
Able to be maintained at a certain rate or level

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 Describe a typical meal you eat during the week.

2 Why do many people find it hard to eat healthily?

3 Should schools teach students how to cook healthy food?



TRY TO USE disregard · scarcity · deficiency · convenience foods · balance

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people think governments should put a tax on unhealthy food and drinks to improve public health. To what extent do you agree or disagree?



ARTICLE 12 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

FOOD SCARES

It's becoming increasingly difficult to be sure that the food we eat isn't actually harmful. We seem to be facing one food scare after another, making many people feel uncertain about their choices.

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It's becoming increasingly difficult to be sure that the food we eat isn't actually harmful. We seem to be facing one **food scare** after another, making many people feel **uncertain** about their choices.

Recently, several of these scares have involved **genetically modified (GM) foods**. While some experts assure us these foods are safe and that concerns are simply **scaremongering**, history has shown such assurances can be wrong. Other experts argue that GM food could potentially be damaging to our health. At best, the issue is still **under debate**.

> *Pesticides, insecticides, and chemical fertilizers also cause concern.*

Many countries require products containing genetically modified ingredients to be labelled accordingly. However, some large food producers now claim that it's becoming harder to **distinguish** GM food from conventional varieties. Meanwhile, public protests continue against the planting of experimental GM crops, reflecting the ongoing **public unease**.

Pesticides, insecticides, and chemical fertilizers also cause concern. Over the past few years, many people have started buying organic produce, even though it's considerably more expensive than food grown using conventional methods. This is largely driven by a desire to avoid **exposing** themselves and their children to potentially toxic chemicals. Consumers are looking for **alternatives**.

Some experts claim that organically grown food isn't necessarily healthier, arguing that the levels of toxins in conventionally grown food are not high enough to be harmful. However, the growing demand for organic food suggests this isn't just a passing trend. Some believe that certain experts may be **biased**, perhaps influenced by the powerful food industry, whose primary concern is increasing food production and, consequently, profits. They may be trying to **downplay** the risks.

The use of additives is another source of **consumer anxiety**. These substances are often added to food to improve its color or flavor. However, some are suspected of causing allergies or even behavioral problems in children. People are becoming more aware of the **potential impact** of these additives.

We need to eat to survive. The question is: what food is truly safe to consume? It's a **fundamental** question with complex answers.

Glossary

01 **food scare**
A period of public concern about the safety of food

02 **uncertain**
Not sure or confident about something

03 **genetically modified (GM) foods**
Foods produced from organisms that have had changes introduced into their DNA using the methods of genetic engineering

04 **scaremongering**
The spreading of frightening or exaggerated reports or rumours in order to cause alarm

05 **under debate**
Being discussed or argued about

06 **distinguish**
Recognize or treat (someone or something) as different

07 **public unease**
A feeling of anxiety or discomfort among the public

08 **exposing**
Making (someone or something) visible by uncovering it

09 **alternatives**
One of two or more available possibilities

10 **biased**
Unfairly prejudiced for or against someone or something

11 **downplay**
Make (something) appear less important than it really is

12 **consumer anxiety**
Worry or fear experienced by consumers, often related to purchasing decisions or product safety

13 **potential impact**
The possible effect or influence that something may have

14 **fundamental**
Forming a necessary base or core; of central importance

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 Do you check where your food comes from before you buy it?

2 How far do you trust the information on food labels?

3 Is organic food worth the extra cost?

TRY TO USE food scare | uncertain | genetically modified (GM) foods | scaremongering | under debate

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people believe genetically modified food could help to end world hunger, while others think it is too risky. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

THE DANGERS OF PASSIVE SMOKING



ARTICLE 13 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

New research has highlighted that even brief exposure to passive smoking, such as just thirty minutes, can cause temporary harm to a non-smoker's heart.

13

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New research has highlighted that even brief exposure to passive smoking, such as just thirty minutes, can cause temporary harm to a non-smoker's heart. While experts have been **raising awareness** about the health risks associated with breathing in other people's cigarette smoke for some time, public understanding of these dangers seems to be lagging behind.

In most countries, people are generally well-informed about the dangers of smoking itself. Whether or not they choose to quit, they are aware that smoking can **lead to** respiratory illnesses, including serious conditions like lung cancer. However, their understanding of the consequences of passive smoking appears to be much more limited. They may not realize the **severity** of the threat.

> *People with asthma often find that their symptoms worsen significantly in environments filled with cigarette smoke.*

Many non-smokers view smoking as an **inconsiderate** habit that causes them discomfort, rather than recognizing it as a genuine health hazard. They might object to smoky environments, dirty ashtrays, or the litter caused by discarded cigarette ends. They may consistently choose non-smoking sections in restaurants or other public places. Yet, a large number of them still don't fully grasp that being around smokers can actually make them sick, which is a **cause for concern**.

It's been known for several years that passive smoking can, to a lesser degree, cause the same respiratory diseases that active smoking does. People with asthma often find that their symptoms **worsen** significantly in environments filled with cigarette smoke. This can **trigger** an attack.

Smokers who are concerned about their health can try to **break free from** their addiction, which is one of the most common forms of dependence. They might rely on their own willpower, or they might use nicotine patches as a **tool** to help them quit. However, non-smokers often have limited options other than avoiding the company of smokers, particularly those who **chain-smoke**. This may lead to **social isolation**.

If you want to minimize the risks of passive smoking, you can take some simple steps. Always avoid designated smoking areas in public places and **enforce** a no-smoking policy in your home. Furthermore, you can politely ask your friends not to smoke in your presence. You never know, they might even start to **reconsider** their own smoking habits, and this could **prompt** them to think about their health.

These small changes can **contribute significantly** to your overall health and well-being. Don't underestimate the **cumulative effect** of protecting yourself from secondhand smoke. It is **paramount** to prioritize your health.

Glossary

01 **raising awareness**
Increasing public knowledge and understanding of a particular issue.

02 **lead to**
To have something as a result.

03 **severity**
The fact or condition of being severe.

04 **inconsiderate**
Thoughtless; lacking consideration for others.

05 **cause for concern**
Something that should make you worried.

06 **worsen**
To become worse.

07 **trigger**
To cause something to start.

08 **break free from**
To escape from something that controls you.

09 **tool**
Something that helps you to do a particular activity.

10 **chain-smoke**
To smoke cigarettes one after another.

11 **social isolation**
Complete or near-complete lack of contact with society.

12 **enforce**
To make people obey a rule or law.

13 **reconsider**
To think again about a decision or opinion.

14 **prompt**
To encourage someone to say or do something.

15 **contribute significantly**
To have a large impact or effect.

16 **cumulative effect**
The total effect of a series of things.

17 **paramount**
More important than anything else.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 Is smoking common among people your age where you live?

2 Should smoking be banned in all public places, including outdoor areas?

3 How can young people be discouraged from starting to smoke?

TRY TO USE raising awareness · lead to · severity · inconsiderate · cause for concern

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people think smoking should be banned completely because it harms not only smokers but also the people around them. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

14



ARTICLE 14 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

A DONOR SHORTAGE

The recent death of Dr. Christiaan Barnard, a pioneer in transplant surgery, highlights the ongoing challenges faced by surgeons in this field.

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The recent death of Dr. Christiaan Barnard, a **pioneer** in transplant surgery, highlights the ongoing challenges faced by surgeons in this field. While significant **strides** have been made in overcoming issues like organ rejection, largely due to advancements in immunosuppressant drugs, a critical problem **persists**: the severe shortage of available organs for transplantation.

This **acute** lack of donors has led to calls for **urgent** improvements in organ donation systems. Countries like the UK have extensive waiting lists of patients whose lives could be dramatically improved, or even saved, through kidney, lung, heart, or liver transplants. Tragically, many of these individuals **succumb** to their illnesses before they can receive a **life-saving** organ.

> *"This approach aims to address the current donor shortage by making donation the default option.*

Currently, the British system relies on individuals carrying donor cards and/or registering on a national donor database, indicating their **consent** for organ donation in the event of their death, for example, following a **fatal** accident. If a person hasn't registered, surgeons must ask the grieving family for permission to use the deceased's organs. Understandably, relatives are often too **distraught** to consider such a request, especially given the limited timeframe for successful organ transplantation. Organs need to be **viable** to transplant.

The difficulty is that death and organ donation are subjects most people avoid thinking about, resulting in a low registration rate – only around 14%. One proposed solution is to shift to an "opt-out" system, where individuals are automatically considered donors unless they **explicitly** register their refusal. This approach aims to **address** the current donor shortage by making donation the default option.

Increasing the number of donors remains a complex challenge due to the **sensitive** nature of the topic. A recent study in the Journal of the American Medical Association revealed that in the United States, approximately half of families decline permission when asked about donating a loved one's organs, highlighting the **deep-seated** emotional and ethical considerations surrounding this issue. It is a very **delicate** matter.

Glossary

01 **pioneer**
A person who is among the first to research or develop a new area of knowledge or activity.

02 **strides**
Significant improvements or progress.

03 **persists**
Continues to exist or occur, especially despite opposition or difficulty.

04 **acute**
Severe or serious.

05 **urgent**
Requiring immediate action or attention.

06 **succumb**
To give way to superior force; to yield.

07 **life-saving**
Preventing death.

08 **consent**
Permission for something to happen or agreement to do something.

09 **fatal**
Causing death.

10 **distraught**
Deeply upset and agitated.

11 **viable**
Capable of working successfully; feasible.

12 **explicitly**
In a clear and detailed manner, leaving no room for confusion or doubt.

13 **address**
To deal with or discuss (a matter or problem).

14 **sensitive**
Easily offended or upset; requiring careful handling.

15 **deep-seated**
Firmly established and difficult to change.

16 **delicate**
Requiring careful handling; sensitive.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 Have you ever donated blood, or would you consider it?

2 Why do you think many people are unwilling to become organ donors?

3 Should people be registered as donors automatically unless they choose not to be?

TRY TO USE pioneer strides persists acute urgent

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

In some countries everyone is automatically an organ donor unless they choose to opt out. Do the advantages of this system outweigh the disadvantages?



ARTICLE 15 · B2

THE BENEFITS OF CHOCOLATE



Most of us have a weakness for sweet things, and chocolate is a favourite, whether it's in sweets, bars, or cakes.

15

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Most of us have a **weakness for** sweet things, and chocolate is a favourite, whether it's in sweets, bars, or cakes. The sheer variety of chocolate products in shops shows just how popular it is. Some of us are even so keen that we could be called chocolate **addicts**.

We're often told that too much sugar and fat is bad for us, and chocolate has plenty of both. So, we've come to think of eating chocolate as a **guilty pleasure**.

> *"Nutritionists have tended to focus on the downsides of chocolate.*

Chocolate often makes us feel good. Even some health experts agree, suggesting it has a **chemical effect** on the brain's pleasure centres. If you're feeling down, a bit of chocolate can be a real **pick-me-up**, cheering you up quickly. However, this effect is usually **short-lived**, and you soon feel low again.

Nutritionists have tended to focus on the **downsides** of chocolate. They point out that the combination of high fat and sugar can cause obesity if you **overindulge**. They also remind us that high-fat foods can lead to heart problems. Chocolate is also thought to cause headaches in some people and is considered a major **trigger** for migraines.

After all that bad news from dieticians, chocolate lovers will be pleased to hear that some doctors have found some benefits. Recent research suggests that chocolate, like aspirin, can **slow down** blood clotting, potentially helping to prevent thrombosis. It's also been found that chocolate, like fruits and vegetables, is rich in flavonoids, which can help prevent heart attacks and strokes. This is especially true of **dark chocolate**.

Finally, some good news for chocolate fans! They can enjoy this delicious treat without feeling too guilty, knowing that it might actually be **beneficial** to their health, though **moderation** is key.

Glossary

01 **weakness for**
A strong liking or fondness for something.

02 **addicts**
People who are unable to stop taking harmful drugs, or doing something as a habit.

03 **guilty pleasure**
Something enjoyable that you feel slightly ashamed about liking.

04 **chemical effect**
The impact of a substance on the body's chemistry.

05 **pick-me-up**
Something that makes you feel better or more energetic.

06 **short-lived**
Lasting for only a short time.

07 **downsides**
The disadvantages or negative aspects of something.

08 **overindulge**
To have too much of something enjoyable, especially food or drink.

09 **trigger**
Something that causes a particular reaction or event.

10 **slow down**
To reduce the speed or rate of something.

11 **dark chocolate**
Chocolate with a high percentage of cocoa solids and little or no added sugar.

12 **beneficial**
Having a good effect; advantageous.

13 **moderation**
The avoidance of excess or extremes, especially in one's behavior or lifestyle.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 What is your favourite treat, and how often do you have it?

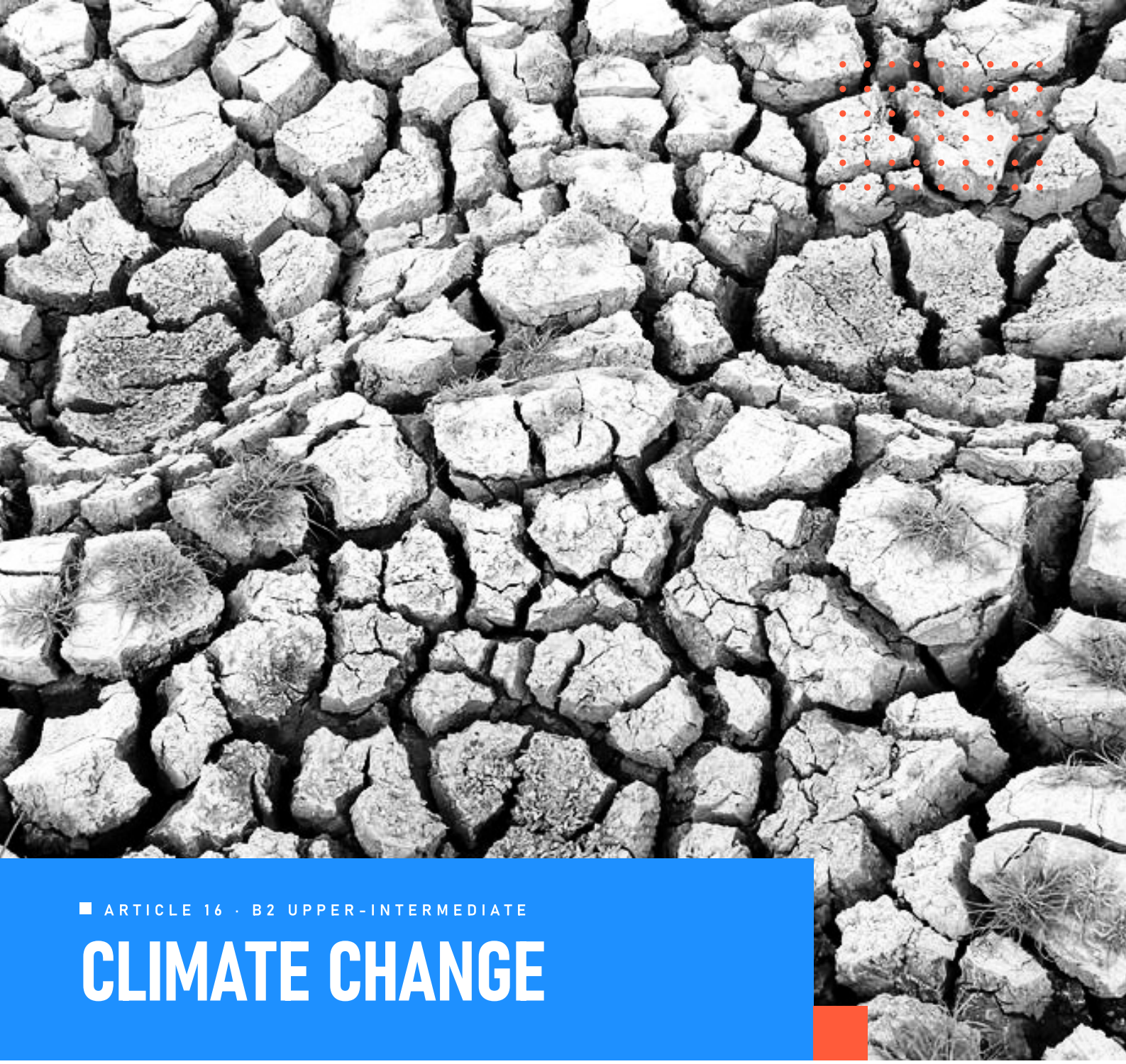
2 Why do people often feel guilty about eating sweet things?

3 Should sweets and chocolate be sold in schools?

TRY TO USE weakness for · addicts · guilty pleasure · chemical effect · pick-me-up

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people say that advice about healthy eating changes so often that it is impossible to know what to believe. To what extent do you agree or disagree?



ARTICLE 16 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

CLIMATE CHANGE

Scientists who study the climate are becoming increasingly worried about the changes happening to our planet's climate.

16

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Scientists who study the climate are becoming increasingly **worried** about the changes happening to our planet's climate. It's true that the Earth's climate has changed before. For instance, we know there have been several ice ages in the past.

However, these past climate shifts were different from what's happening now. They occurred slowly and, as far as we understand, due to natural processes. The changes we're seeing today are believed to be caused by human activities, not natural ones. What's more, the speed of these changes is becoming **alarmingly fast**.

> *"It's thought that this unusual warming is caused by greenhouse gases, such as carbon dioxide.*

The main concern is that the Earth seems to be getting warmer. Some experts say this warming, known as global warming, is happening faster than at any time in the last 10,000 years. This has **serious implications** for the planet. Rising temperatures could lead to ecological disasters, like a big increase in floods and droughts. These events could then **negatively affect** farming and food production.

It's thought that this unusual warming is caused by **greenhouse gases**, such as carbon dioxide. These gases are released into the atmosphere by things like car engines and modern factories. These gases not only pollute the air but also create a 'greenhouse effect'. This means they trap the sun's heat, leading to the planet warming up. **Deforestation** also contributes to the problem, as trees absorb greenhouse gases.

Politicians are also concerned about climate change, and there are regular international meetings, or **summits**, on the topic. Representatives from many of the world's industrialized countries attend these. One of the most important summits took place in Kyoto, Japan, in 1997. There, it was agreed that industrialized countries should try to **reduce their emissions** of greenhouse gases and were given specific goals to achieve this reduction. **Measures** like planting more forests were suggested to absorb greenhouse gases.

Unfortunately, the agreed targets are often **not being met**. Even more concerning is that warnings about climate change are still often **dismissed as** exaggeration or **scaremongering**. This **lack of action** poses a significant threat to our planet's future and requires immediate attention.

Glossary

01 **worried**
Anxious or concerned about actual or potential problems.

02 **alarmingly fast**
Happening at a rate that causes concern or fear.

03 **serious implications**
Important or significant consequences.

04 **negatively affect**
To have a bad impact on something.

05 **greenhouse gases**
Gases that trap heat in the atmosphere, contributing to global warming.

06 **deforestation**
The clearing of forests.

07 **summits**
High-level meetings between leaders of countries.

08 **reduce their emissions**
To decrease the amount of gases released into the atmosphere.

09 **measures**
Actions taken to achieve a particular purpose.

10 **not being met**
Not being achieved or fulfilled.

11 **dismissed as**
To reject something as not worthy of consideration.

12 **scaremongering**
The spreading of frightening or exaggerated reports to cause alarm.

13 **lack of action**
Failure to take any steps to deal with a situation.

14 **poses a significant threat**
Creates a serious danger or risk.

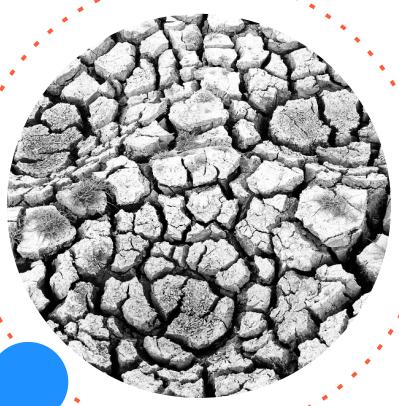
15 **requires immediate attention**
Needs to be dealt with urgently.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 Have you noticed any changes in the weather where you live?

2 What everyday actions can people take to protect the climate?

3 Why do some people still not take climate change seriously?



TRY TO USE worried | alarmingly fast | serious implications | negatively affect | greenhouse gases

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people think individuals can do little to stop climate change and that only governments and large companies can make a real difference. To what extent do you agree or disagree?



ARTICLE 17 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

ENDANGERED SPECIES

It's now widely understood that our modern lifestyles are significantly damaging the environment. This includes the detrimental impact we're having on animal populations.

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It's now widely understood that our modern lifestyles are significantly damaging the environment. This includes the **detrimental impact** we're having on animal populations. In fact, we're **jeopardizing** the survival of numerous species, potentially pushing them to extinction.

For millennia, animal extinction was a natural part of evolution. However, in recent times, human activities have become a primary driver of species extinction. Without our interference, many more animals would likely have continued to thrive. Human actions have **accelerated** what would have been a natural process.

> *During this period, commercial hunting expanded beyond basic needs like food and clothing.*

Hunting has either caused the extinction of some species or placed them on the **endangered list**. Early humans hunted for survival, using animal flesh for food and skins for clothing, undoubtedly contributing to the gradual disappearance of certain animals. However, the introduction of firearms, with their enhanced accuracy, **posed a significant threat** to specific species. From the nineteenth century onwards, several animals were on the **verge of extinction** due to hunting.

During this period, commercial hunting expanded beyond basic needs like food and clothing. For example, elephants were hunted extensively for their ivory. While attempts are now being made to regulate this **large-scale** commercial hunting, enforcement can be difficult in some regions. Consequently, animals continue to be killed for profit. However, commercial interests aren't solely responsible. Sport hunting has also **played a role** in the extinction of particular species.

A more contemporary threat to many animals is the **destruction of habitat** and the resulting disruption of entire ecosystems. Our use of pesticides and other chemicals has polluted both soil and water, proving **toxic** to many plants essential to animal habitats. Furthermore, we routinely **clear land** previously inhabited by animals to accommodate growing populations or, as with deforestation, to provide resources for wealthier countries. This is a **pressing issue** that needs addressing.

Modern living has had a **destructive effect** on the ecosystem. To preserve our wildlife, we must actively work to **reverse this trend** and find more sustainable ways of living. It's a **shared responsibility**.

Glossary

01 **detrimental impact**
A harmful or damaging effect.

02 **jeopardizing**
Putting someone or something at risk.

03 **accelerated**
To increase the rate or speed of something.

04 **endangered list**
A list of species that are at risk of extinction.

05 **posed a significant threat**
Presented a serious danger or risk.

06 **verge of extinction**
Very close to becoming extinct.

07 **large-scale**
Extensive or on a grand scale.

08 **played a role**
Had an effect or influence.

09 **destruction of habitat**
The damaging or ruining of the natural environment where a species lives.

10 **toxic**
Poisonous or very harmful.

11 **clear land**
To remove trees, vegetation, and other obstacles from an area of land.

12 **pressing issue**
A problem that needs to be dealt with urgently.

13 **destructive effect**
An action or process that causes great damage.

14 **reverse this trend**
To change a situation so that it becomes the opposite of what it was.

15 **shared responsibility**
A duty or obligation that is held by more than one person or group.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 Which wild animal would you most like to protect, and why?

2 Are zoos good or bad for endangered animals?

3 Why does it matter if a species disappears that most people never see?



TRY TO USE detrimental impact · jeopardizing · accelerated · endangered list · posed a significant threat

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people argue that money spent on protecting endangered animals would be better spent on helping people. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

MODERN CELEBRITIES



ARTICLE 18 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

The media, especially television, often gets the blame for many of society's problems. Therefore, it's not surprising that they are also accused of fueling our current obsession with celebrities.

18

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The media, especially television, often gets the blame for many of society's problems. Therefore, it's not surprising that they are also accused of fueling our current **obsession** with celebrities.

What's quite odd is that many individuals considered famous today seem to lack a real reason for their **celebrity status**. Some might be actors, athletes, or singers, but others appear to gain fame simply by being associated with someone already famous, wearing outrageous outfits, or behaving badly in public. In fact, for some, it's **infamy** rather than true fame that they achieve.

> *Modern celebrities often go to great lengths to stay in the tabloids.*

While past generations certainly had their icons, fame back then seemed to be based more on genuine talent and tended to last longer. Today's celebrities often experience **fleeting fame**; they might be in the spotlight for a short time and then quickly disappear. This is a stark contrast to the lasting **legacy** of Hollywood legends like James Dean, who remain famous long after they've died. Their talent **transcended** time.

Modern celebrities often go to great lengths to stay in the tabloids. Their image is **paramount**, and they crave publicity. Although they sometimes complain about the paparazzi, they seem unable to live without media attention. They appear desperate to remain in the public eye once they've achieved it. The worst thing for them is to be **eclipsed** by someone else.

Everything they do is **exaggerated**, with image consultants working hard to ensure their lives are constantly publicised. They are driven by the pursuit of wealth and fame, although much of their earnings are spent on their **lavish lifestyles**. It is as if they are trying to **outdo** each other in displays of wealth.

And if their careers begin to **wane**, some resort to giving sensational interviews, perhaps claiming they've overcome addictions to alcohol, drugs, or eating disorders. It's rather sad that many of today's so-called heroes are not particularly **admirable**; they lack the qualities we traditionally associate with heroism. They are more concerned with **self-promotion** than anything else.

Glossary

01 **obsession**
A state in which someone thinks about someone or something constantly or frequently.

02 **celebrity status**
The condition of being famous or well-known.

03 **infamy**
The state of being well known for some bad quality or deed.

04 **fleeting fame**
Fame that lasts only for a short time.

05 **legacy**
Something transmitted by or received from an ancestor or predecessor or from the past.

06 **transcended**
To rise above or go beyond the limits of.

07 **paramount**
More important than anything else; supreme.

08 **eclipsed**
To surpass in importance or reputation; outshine.

09 **exaggerated**
Represented as greater than is actually the case; overstated.

10 **lavish lifestyles**
Extravagant and luxurious ways of living.

11 **outdo**
To be more successful than someone else.

12 **wane**
To decrease in vigor, power, or extent; become weaker.

13 **admirable**
Deserving respect and approval.

14 **self-promotion**
The publicizing of oneself or one's accomplishments.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 Is there a famous person you admire? Why?

2 Why are so many young people interested in celebrities' private lives?

3 Do celebrities have a responsibility to be good role models?



TRY TO USE obsession · celebrity status · infamy · fleeting fame · legacy

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Today many people become famous without any particular talent or achievement. Is this a positive or a negative development?

19



ARTICLE 19 · B2 UPPER-INTERMEDIATE

THE RIGHT TO DIE

Recent changes in European Union human rights laws have led to more people asserting their rights. In Britain, the most recent example of this is the invocation of the right to die.

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Recent changes in European Union human rights laws have led to more people **asserting** their rights. In Britain, the most recent example of this is the **invocation** of the right to die.

Currently, a woman is trying to prove that the British government is violating the European Convention on Human Rights by forcing her to live in what she considers **inhumane** and **degrading** conditions. She suffers from motor neurone disease, a disease that **inevitably** leads to death and the **gradual loss** of muscle function.

> *"Her court case is supported by the Voluntary Euthanasia Society.*

The woman is **demanding** the right to die with dignity, at a time of her choosing. Having lost the ability to control most of her body, although her mind is still clear, she wants to be allowed to end her own life, arguing that her quality of life is now **unacceptable**. However, her physical condition prevents her from committing suicide without assistance. She hopes the courts will agree not to prosecute her husband if he helps her to die. This is also called **assisted dying**.

Her court case is supported by the Voluntary Euthanasia Society. Its members believe that euthanasia should be a **genuine option** for people in the final stages of terminal illnesses, who are experiencing such severe pain or such a complete loss of ability that they no longer wish to live. They argue that such people should be legally allowed **access to** assisted suicide, possibly with the help of a doctor.

Over the years, many arguments have been made in favour of legalising euthanasia, but some people fear that it could **pave the way for** murder, unless strict **safeguards** were in place. **Mercy killing**, also known as euthanasia, is illegal in most countries, although it has recently been legalised in the Netherlands.

Several countries are currently considering the issue of **advance directives**, sometimes called 'living wills'. These documents are created by people while they are healthy, stating that they wish to **exercise** their right to die, or to be helped to die, if they ever reach a point where death would be a welcome **relief** from a terrible and incurable condition. The court's decision in this case is still **pending**. One thing is certain: the debate on this difficult and emotional subject will continue to **rage**.

Glossary

01 **asserting**
Stating a right or fact confidently and forcefully

02 **invocation**
The act of referring to something, especially a law or principle, in order to support your case.

03 **inhumane**
Cruel and brutal; without compassion for suffering.

04 **degrading**
Causing someone to feel ashamed and humiliated.

05 **inevitably**
As is certain to happen; unavoidably.

06 **gradual loss**
A slow and progressive decline or disappearance.

07 **demanding**
Requesting something forcefully, as if it were one's due.

08 **unacceptable**
Not satisfactory or allowable.

09 **assisted dying**
Providing assistance to someone who wishes to end their life.

10 **genuine option**
A real and valid choice.

11 **access to**
The opportunity or right to use something or enter a place.

12 **pave the way for**
Create the conditions or opportunities for something to happen.

13 **safeguards**
Measures taken to protect someone or something or to prevent something undesirable.

14 **mercy killing**
The act of deliberately ending a person's life to relieve suffering.

15 **advance directives**
A written statement of a person's wishes regarding medical treatment, often including a living will, made to ensure those wishes are carried out should the person be unable to communicate them to a doctor.

16 **exercise**
Use or apply (a right, power, or quality).

17 **relief**
A feeling of reassurance and relaxation following release from anxiety or distress.

18 **pending**
Awaiting decision or settlement.

19 **rage**
Continue with great intensity.

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER

1 Why are some moral questions so hard for a society to agree on?

2 Who should make important medical decisions: patients, doctors or families?

3 Should laws change when public opinion changes?



TRY TO USE asserting invocation inhumane degrading inevitably

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people believe that patients with incurable illnesses should have the right to make decisions about the end of their own lives, while others think this is too dangerous to allow. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.



ARTICLE 20 · B2

ALL KINDS OF RAGE



It appears that more and more people are experiencing anger, or at least, are expressing their frustration more openly.

20

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It appears that more and more people are experiencing anger, or at least, are **expressing their frustration** more openly. We seem to be losing our temper in various situations, and anger has become so prevalent that new terms have emerged to describe specific types of angry outbursts.

The first widely recognised form of this is **road rage**. This term refers to drivers who become so infuriated by the actions of other drivers or pedestrians that they completely lose control of their emotions. They might exit their vehicles to shout and make **threatening gestures** at those who have annoyed them. In extreme cases, they become so **overwhelmed by rage** that they physically attack others, and there have even been instances of drivers losing control and causing fatal accidents. It often doesn't take much to **trigger** drivers who are **prone to anger**; even a legal overtaking manoeuvre can provoke them.

> *Supermarkets are another common setting for anger to surface.*

Police intervention is sometimes required in domestic situations where anger **escalates out of control**. In the most serious cases, individuals who struggle to manage their temper may **resort to** domestic abuse, physically assaulting their partners. This can frequently lead to the breakdown of the family unit and, in some instances, the imprisonment of the **abusive partner**.

Supermarkets are another common setting for anger to surface. Customers often experience frustration when they have to queue at the checkouts, sometimes becoming so enraged that they are driven to **trolley rage**. This involves deliberately colliding with other shoppers using their shopping trolleys, potentially causing injuries.

Passengers on aeroplanes can also **lose their cool**. Known as **air rage**, this type of anger is typically directed at the cabin crew. It's common for passengers who become angry on board to have consumed excessive amounts of alcohol in airport bars and to be **in an aggressive mood** when they board the aircraft. Their violent behaviour is dangerous in flight, and they often need to be restrained.

Try to avoid allowing yourself to fall into these patterns. Take a moment to **compose yourself** and manage your anger effectively!

Glossary

01 **expressing their frustration**
Showing that you are annoyed or upset because you cannot achieve something

02 **road rage**
Anger or violence between drivers because of difficult or annoying traffic conditions

03 **threatening gestures**
Actions or movements that suggest someone intends to cause harm

04 **overwhelmed by rage**
Feeling a very strong feeling of anger that is difficult to control

05 **trigger**
To cause something to start

06 **prone to anger**
Likely to become angry easily

07 **escalates out of control**
Increases rapidly and becomes impossible to manage

08 **resort to**
To do something that you do not want to do because there is no other choice

09 **abusive partner**
A partner who treats someone badly physically or emotionally

10 **trolley rage**
Anger and aggression in a supermarket, often involving collisions with shopping trolleys

11 **lose their cool**
To become angry

12 **air rage**
Anger or violence shown by a passenger on an aircraft

13 **in an aggressive mood**
Ready or likely to attack or confront

14 **compose yourself**
To calm yourself down

SPEAKING DISCUSS WITH A PARTNER



1 What kinds of situations make you feel stressed or annoyed?

2 Why do people seem to lose their temper more easily nowadays?

3 What are good ways to calm down when you feel angry?

TRY TO USE expressing their frustration · road rage · threatening gestures · overwhelmed by rage · trigger

ESSAY · ABOUT 200 WORDS

Some people believe that modern life is making people more stressed and aggressive. What are the causes of this, and what can be done about it?

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